

The Raman EFFECT

The majority hides the fact that a meagre vote margin of 1.5 per cent differentiates the winner from the loser

| By Ambresh Mishra |

With his plus-size frame, Dr Raman Singh keeps a close tab on what he eats and usually helps himself with small meals for dinner. Yet for the impoverished masses of Chhattisgarh, the genial Ayurveda practitioner loosened the Government's purse-strings so that nobody had to sleep on an empty stomach. By the time 'Chaur Wale Baba' ('the elder who provides rice' in local Chhattisgarhi dialect) was through with his populist Rs 3-per-kg rice scheme, the entire state was eating out of his hand. Humility has always been his virtue. But for a chief minister who never had any pretensions of running a super-efficient government, a prescient political eye did the trick in the end.

Around the same time as schemes like free bovines for tribal families turned out to be impractical, Raman's political fortunes also nosedived. The BJP lost crucial by-elections, dissident tribal leaders of the party rallied against him and even some of his Cabinet and party colleagues turned into bitter critics. To the credit of the party's top brass, it persisted with him, telling off the dissenters. BJP General Secretary Ravi Shankar Prasad points out the role of Saudan Singh, the national BJP organising secretary. An old Chhattisgarhi hand, he was the architect of the strategy that helped the party win a tough election. Dr Raman Singh, on his part, has now repaid the debt of gratitude by capturing Chhattisgarh with the slimmest of margins. The 12-seat difference between the BJP's 50 and the Congress's 38 seems a comfortable win in a relatively smaller House of 90. But a close scrutiny of the percentage of votes polled by the two protagonists reveals it was a photo-finish. The BJP polled 40.46 per cent of the vote to Congress's 39.05, a sliver of less than 1.5 per cent of the vote separating the winner and the loser.

The BJP's creditable performance in the Naxal-infested South Bastar districts also vindicated the Salwa Judum movement that his Government has backed to the hilt. Ironically, Congress's own tribal stalwart, Mahendra Karma, who had jumped on board with Singh on the anti-Naxal plank, came in a poor third after the BJP and the CPI. If Sheila Dikshit in Delhi got projected as the Congress's candidate, it was by default for being the chief minister. In Chhattisgarh, an IAS officer-turned-politician,



DR RAMAN SINGH SAVOURS THE CLOSE WIN

Singh's stewardship of the campaign is creditable as the victory came after the BJP's successive by-election losses.

Ajit Jogi, occupied the same space against Singh by design, even if he didn't proclaim it in so many words. And he gave the BJP a run for its money.

Ailing and wheelchair-bound, Jogi was still the only Congress leader on the campaign trail across the state, drawing inevitable comparison with Singh at a time when most voters have come to expect more personality-based elections. Jogi gave it his all, crisscrossing the state in a helicopter but came up just short of Singh even as former Union minister and party's stalwart of the '70s, '80s and '90s Vidya Charan Shukla watched helplessly from the sidelines. In 2003, Shukla was the head of the NCP state unit that had polled a shade over 7 per cent of the vote, denying the Congress a victory. This time, the BSP's vote share rose by a thin 1.68 per cent to 6.13. The Dalit outfit that contested all the 90 seats didn't have much to show by way